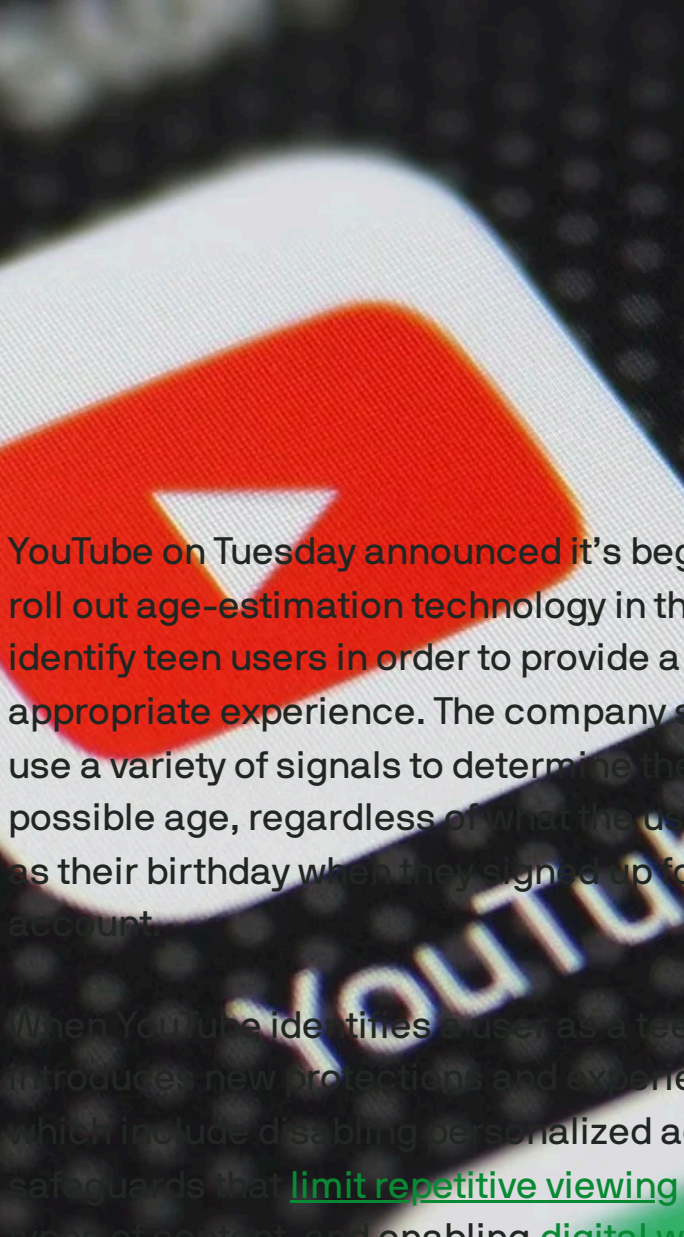


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APPS



YouTube rolls out age-
estimation tech to
identify US teens and
apply additional
protections



YouTube on Tuesday announced it's beginning to roll out age-estimation technology in the U.S. to identify teen users in order to provide a more age-appropriate experience. The company says it will use a variety of signals to determine the users' possible age, regardless of what the user entered as their birthday when they signed up for an account.

When YouTube identifies a user as a teen, it introduces new protections and experiences, which include disabling personalized advertising, safeguards that [limit repetitive viewing](#) of certain types of content, and enabling [digital well-being tools](#) such as screen time and bedtime reminders, among others.

IMAGE CREDITS: TFGHCRUNCH

These protections already exist on YouTube, but have only been applied to those who verified themselves as teens, not those who may have withheld their real age. For instance, in 2023, [YouTube began limiting repeated viewing of videos](#) that could trigger body image issues or those that display social aggression. The company has also been developing [digital well-being tools since 2018](#).

If the new system incorrectly identifies a user as under 18 when they are not, YouTube says the user will be given the option to verify their age with a credit card, government ID, or selfie. Only users who have been directly verified through this method or whose age has been inferred to be over 18 will be

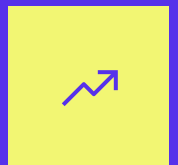
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able to view the age-restricted content on the platform.

The machine learning-powered technology will begin to roll out over the next few weeks to a small set of U.S. users and will then be monitored before rolling out more widely, the company says.

The plans to introduce age inference technology were [announced in February](#) as part of YouTube's 2025 roadmap. The plans are also the latest step in attempting to make YouTube safer for younger users, following the [2015 launch of the YouTube Kids app](#) and the [2024 rollout of supervised accounts](#). The features also arrive as social media more broadly is coming under increased government scrutiny in the United States, where platform makers, including Apple and Google, [have pitted their lobbyists against those from big tech companies](#) like Meta over who's responsible for age verification and children's safety.

In the meantime, a handful of U.S. states have taken matters into their own hands, as [over a dozen](#) states have passed or proposed laws to regulate minors' use of social media. Many of these require age verification or parental consent, including those in Louisiana, Arkansas, Florida, Georgia, Utah, Texas, Maryland, Tennessee, and Connecticut, among others. (However, some laws, like those in Utah and Arkansas, are blocked by litigation at this time and are not enforceable, while others are still pending implementation.)

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The U.K. also began enforcing its [own age-verification checks](#) this week following the 2023 passing of the Online Safety Act.

YouTube isn't sharing specifics about the signals it's using to infer a user's age, but notes that it will look at some data like the YouTube activity and the longevity of a user's account to make a determination if the user is under 18.

The new system will apply only to signed-in users, as signed-out users already cannot access age-restricted content, and will be available across platforms, including web, mobile, and connected TV.

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Google is experimenting with machine learning-powered age-estimation tech in the US

Ivan Mehta — 6:05 AM PDT · July 31, 2025

Google is testing a machine learning-powered tech in the U.S. to determine the age of users and filter content across all its products accordingly.

The company said it will consider data from Google accounts, including types of details users have searched for or categories of videos they have watched on YouTube, to determine the age. If the company's tool decides that a user is under 18, they

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would get an email with details about how Google products might change for them.

For these users, Google will disable the timeline in Maps, stop personalized ads, restrict age-restricted ad categories, and bar them from accessing adult-themed apps on the Play Store. The company will also turn on [digital well-being features](#) on YouTube, such as break reminders and “go to bed” notifications when consuming videos late at night. Plus, it will prevent underage users from accessing certain kinds of content — [such as content that could trigger body image issues](#) — repeatedly.

If users think they have been tagged as an underage account by mistake, they can appeal the decision and prove their age using a photo of their government ID or a selfie.

Google rolled out [similar measures for YouTube earlier this week](#), and now the company is experimenting with machine learning-based age gating in the U.S. for Google accounts at large. The company said that it has experimented with age-estimation tech in some markets (without specifying which ones), and it worked well.

“Age assurance helps us ensure that adults can access the information and services they need, while also applying the right protections for our younger users. Our approach to age assurance uses a combination of age estimation and, when necessary, age verification,” Google [said in a post](#).

Other platforms, [including](#) Instagram and [Roblox](#), have also started using AI to estimate the age of their users. Lawmakers have been at work to put in rules related to serving appropriate content to minors. In the U.S., several states have existing or proposed laws around age gating. Meanwhile,

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Ivan covers global consumer tech developments at TechCrunch. He is based out of India and has previously...

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Google lobbies against
legally mandated age
verification for minors

Google is challenging proposed laws that would require online services to implement age checks in a new [framework](#) that theorizes how technology companies should approach children's safety online. The framework, titled the "Legislative Framework to Protect Children and Teens Online," is the tech giant's response to congressional child online safety proposals.

In its set of principles, Google dismisses policies that would require online services to verify the age of their users before allowing them access to their platforms. For instance, Utah [passed a law](#) that aims to start requiring social media companies to verify the age of a user seeking to maintain or open an account. Google says that such age verification policies will lead to trade-offs and possibly restrict access to important information.

"Good legislative models — like those based on age-appropriate design principles — can help hold companies responsible for promoting safety and privacy, while enabling access to richer experiences for children and teens," the company wrote in a [blog post](#) announcing the framework. "Of course, as policymakers contemplate these issues, they should carefully consider the broader impacts of these bills and avoid side effects like blocking access to critical services, requiring people (including adults) to submit unnecessary identification or sensitive personal information."

The company states that "data-intrusive methods," such as verification with government IDs, should be

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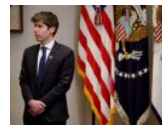
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limited to “high-risk” services that deal with alcohol, gambling, or porn. For context, Louisiana recently [passed a law](#) that requires age verification to access adult websites in an attempt to prevent kids from seeing online porn. Google’s framework is not against age verification in this manner.

Google argues that instead of implementing legislation that would require online services to verify ages, these companies should be required to “prioritize the best interests of children and teens in the design of their products.” Google says that online services used by children and teens should be required to assess the collective interests of children based on “expert research and best practices, to ensure that they are developing, designing and offering age-appropriate products and services.”

In other words, Google says online services shouldn’t be forced to block teens and children from their platforms, and should instead be required to design products appropriately.

Today’s framework comes four years after the Federal Trade Commission (FTC) [fined Google and YouTube \\$170 million](#) for violating children’s privacy. The FTC said YouTube illegally collected personal information from children and used it to profit by targeting them with ads. As part of the settlement, the FTC said YouTube had to develop and maintain a system that asks channel owners to identify their child-directed content to ensure that targeted ads are not placed in such videos.



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Interestingly, Google's framework notes that there should be legislation banning personalized advertising for children and teens. Earlier this year, Senator Ed Markey (D-Mass.) [announced](#) the reintroduction of the Children and Teens' Online Privacy Protection Act (COPPA 2.0), which would ban targeted ads to minors. Google argues that "for those under 18, legislation should ban personalized advertising, including personalization based on a user's age, gender, or interests."

In a separate [online safety framework](#) published today by YouTube, the video platform's CEO Neal Mohan said the service doesn't serve personalized ads to kids.

Despite this claim, [a recent report](#) from advertising performance optimization platform Adalytics alleges that YouTube continues to serve targeted ads to minors. In a [blog post](#), Google stated that Adalytics' report was "deeply flawed and uninformed." The report caught the attention of Senator Marsha Blackburn (R-Tenn.) and Senator Markey, who [sent a letter](#) to the FTC asking the government agency to investigate the matter.

Topics: [children's privacy](#) [Google](#)



Aisha Malik

Consumer News Reporter |

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